



HIL DID MISS A FAIR DEAL BY NOT ONBOARDING A PRIVATE BROADCAST PARTNER AHEAD OF THE AUCTION, BUT EVENTUALLY, THE MULTILINGUAL TELECAST RIGHTS WERE SOLD TO THE SONY SPORTS NETWORK ON DECEMBER 13

Set the ball rolling: Ishika Chaudhary was the first player to be picked during the Hockey India League 2024-25 women's auction, with Odisha Warriors acquiring her services for Rs 16 lakh. R.V. MOORTHY

(JSHC), Shrachi Rahr Bengal Tigers (SRBT) and the Warriors. These four franchises will compete in a round-robin format, playing each other twice in the pool stage that continues until 24 January. **The top two teams on the leaderboard will then clash in the finale on 26 January.**

The inclusion of foreign players adds to the star value of HIL-W, but

the competition has witnessed a slew of pull-outs ahead of the upcoming iteration. As many as eight foreign players have backed out, including the Dutch duo of Olympic, World and European champion Xan Gardien de Waard and triple Olympic champion Eva Drummond, Great Britain's

Commonwealth Games 2022 gold medallist Anna Toman and her compatriot and double Olympic medallist Giselle Anne Ansley, among others.

The reasons cited for the mass exodus range from financial shortcomings and injury